Introduction to Machine Learning

ML-Basics: What is Machine Learning?

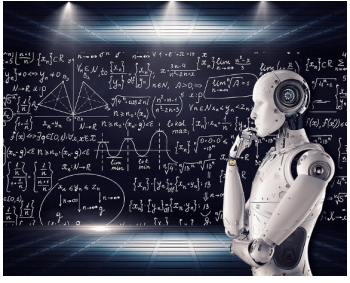
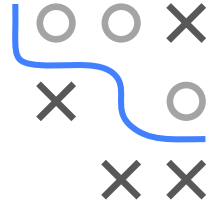


Image via `www.vpnsrus.com`

Learning goals

- Understand basic terminology of and connections between ML, AI, DL and statistics
- Know the main directions of ML: Supervised, Unsupervised and Reinforcement Learning

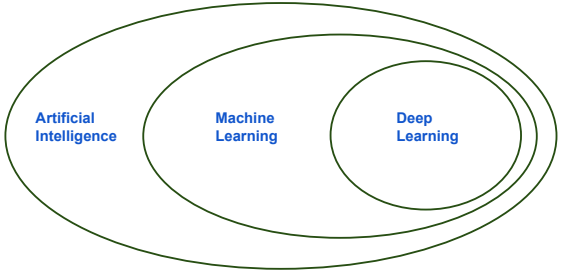
MACHINE LEARNING IS CHANGING OUR WORLD



- Search engines learn what you want
- Recommender systems learn your taste in books, music, movies,...
- Algorithms do automatic stock trading
- Google Translate learns how to translate text
- Siri learns to understand speech
- DeepMind beats humans at Go
- Cars drive themselves
- Smart-watches monitor your health
- Election campaigns use algorithmically targeted ads to influence voters
- Data-driven discoveries are made in physics, biology, genetics, astronomy, chemistry, neurology,...
- ...

THE WORLD OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

... and the connections to Machine Learning and Deep Learning



Many people are confused what these terms actually mean.

And what does all this have to do with statistics?

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

- AI is a general term for a very large and rapidly developing field.
- There is no strict definition of AI, but it's often used when machines are trained to perform on tasks which until that time could only be solved by humans or are very difficult and assumed to require "intelligence".
- AI started in the 1940s - when the computer was invented. Scientists like Turing and John von Neumann immediately asked the question: If we can formalize computation, can we use computation to formalize "thinking"?
- AI includes machine learning, natural language processing, computer vision, robotics, planning, search, game playing, intelligent agents, and much more.
- Nowadays, AI is a "hype" term that many people use when they should probably say: ML or ... basic data analysis.

MACHINE LEARNING

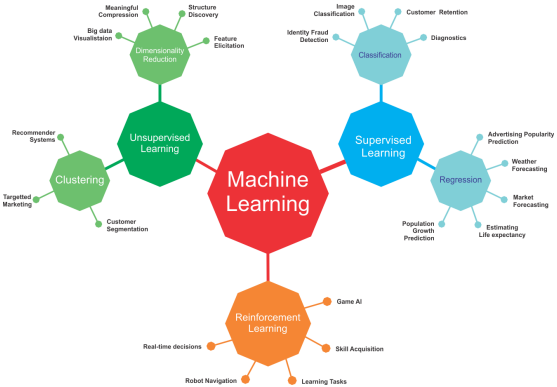
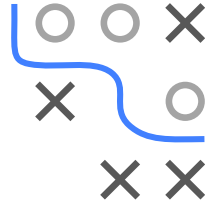


Image via `https://www.oreilly.com/library/view/java-deep-learning/9781788997454/assets/899ceaf3-c710-4675-ae99-33c76cd6ac2f.png`

- Mathematically well-defined and solves reasonably narrow tasks.
- ML algorithms usually construct predictive/decision models from data, instead of explicitly programming them.
- A computer program is said to learn from experience E with respect to some task T and some performance measure P, if its performance on T, as measured by P, improves with experience E.
  Tom Mitchell, Carnegie Mellon University, 1998

DEEP LEARNING



- DL is a subfield of ML which studies neural networks.
- Artificial neural networks (ANNs) might have been (roughly) inspired by the human brain, but they are simply a certain model class of ML.
- ANNs have been studied for decades. DL uses more layers, specific neurons were invented for images and tensors and many computational improvements allow training on large data.
- DL can be used on tabular data, but typical applications are images, texts or signals.
- The last 10-15 years have produced remarkable results and imitations of human ability, where the result looked intelligent.

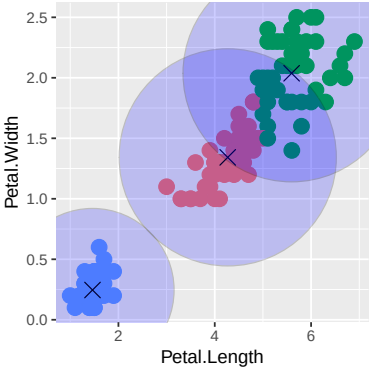
"Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic."
Arthur C. Clarke's 3rd law

ML VS. STATS

- ML and Statistics have historically been developed in different fields, but many methods and especially the mathematical foundations are equivalent.
- Traditionally, models from ML focused more on precise predictions whereas models from statistics focused more on the ability to interpret the patterns that generated the data and the ability to derive sound inference.
- Nowadays, ML and predictive modelling in statistics basically work on the same problems with the same tools.
- Unfortunately, the communities are still divided, don't talk to each other as much as they should and everyone is confused due to different terminology for the same concepts.
- Most parts of ML we could also call:
  Nonparametric statistics plus efficient numerical optimization.

UNSUPERVISED LEARNING

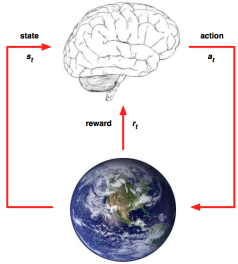
- Data without labels y
- Search for patterns within the inputs x
- *Unsupervised* as there is no “true” output we can optimize against



- Dimensionality reduction (PCA, Autoencoders ...); compress information in $\mathcal{X}$
- Clustering: group similar observations
- Outlier detection, anomaly detection
- Association rules

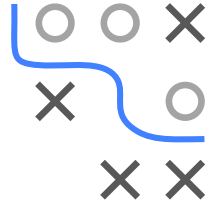
REINFORCEMENT LEARNING

RL is a general-purpose framework for AI. At each time step an *agent* interacts with *environment*. It: observes state; receives reward; executes action.



- Goal: Select actions to maximize future reward.
- Reward signals may be sparse, noisy and delayed.

WHAT COMES NEXT



- We will deal with **supervised learning** for regression and classification: predicting labels y based on features x, using patterns that we learned from labeled data.
- First, we will go through fundamental concepts in supervised ML:
  - What kind of "data" do we learn from?
  - How can we formalize the goal of learning?
  - What is a "prediction model"?
  - How can we quantify "predictive performance"?
  - What is a "learning algorithm"
  - How can we operationalize learning?
- We will also look at a couple of fairly simple ML models to obtain a basic understanding.
- More complex stuff comes later.